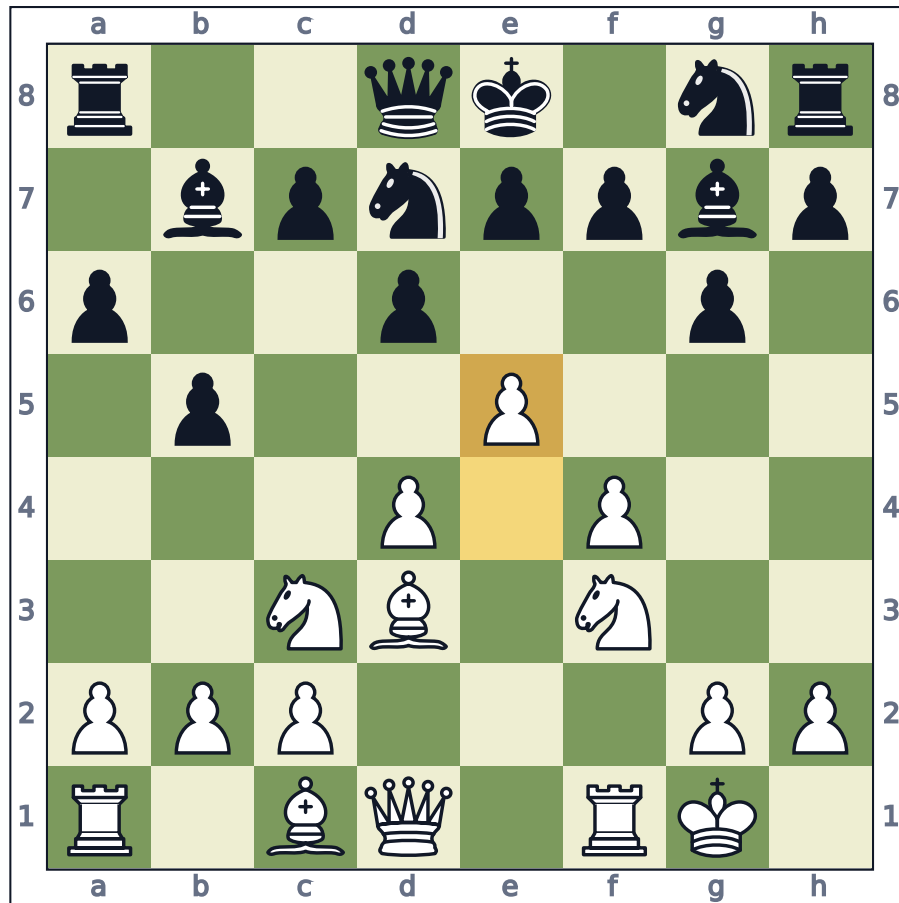


Modern Defense

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BOTH SIDES

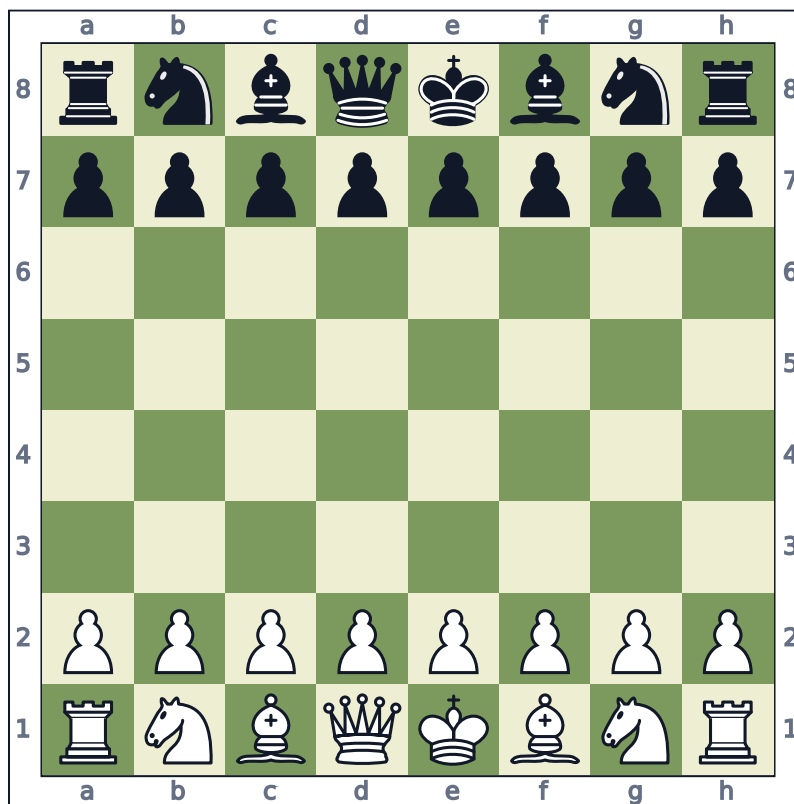
OPENING IDENTITY

Black delays committing the center and seeks flexible counterplay from a fianchetto.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

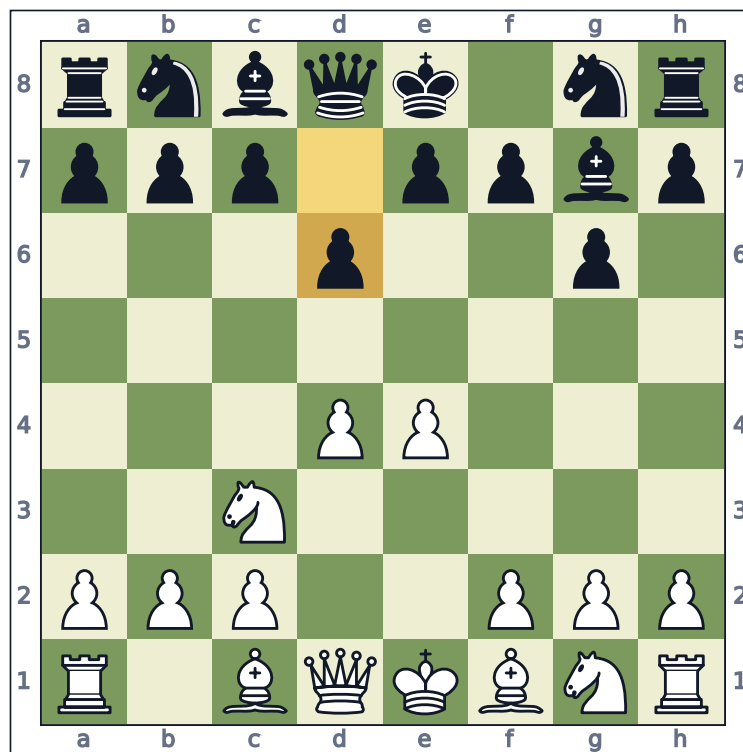
1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6

Course promise: Delay commitment, not development forever.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6



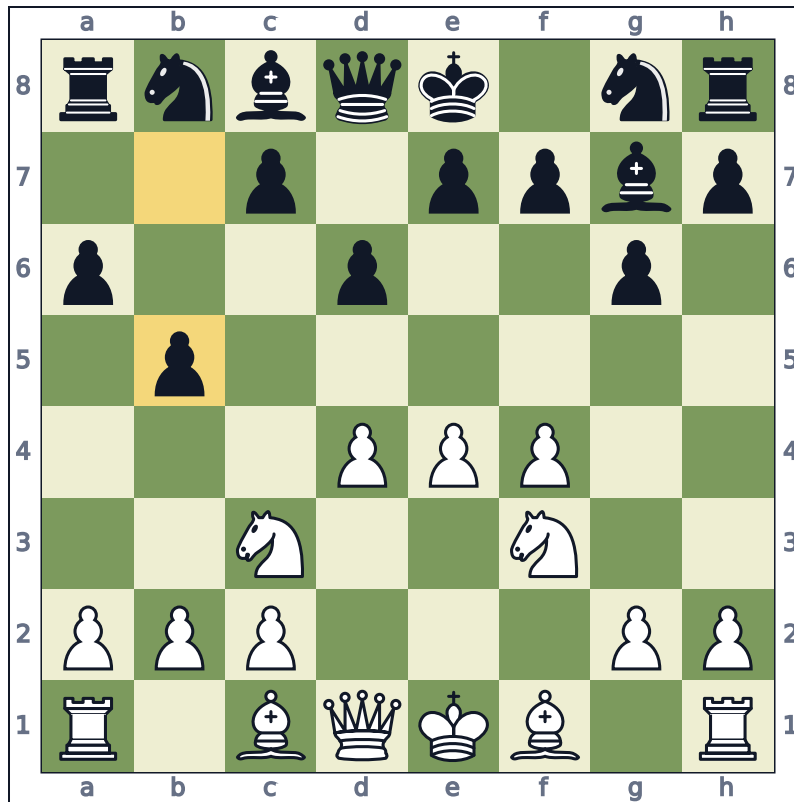
After 3. Nc3 d6

- 1. e4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... g6 - Gains wing space, but also changes squares that can no longer be protected by this pawn.
- 2. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 2... Bg7 - Develops on an active diagonal, often adding a pin or long-range pressure.
- 3. Nc3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3... d6 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 a6 5. Nf3 b5



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Black delays committing the center and seeks flexible counterplay from a fianchetto.

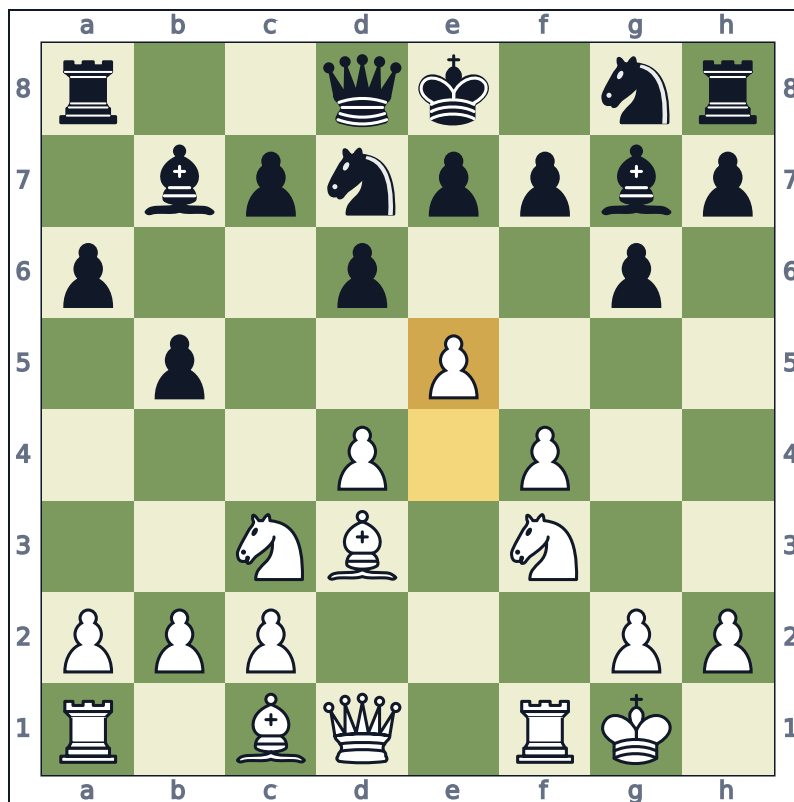
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 a6 5. Nf3 b5 6. Bd3 Nd7 7. O-O Bb7 8. e5



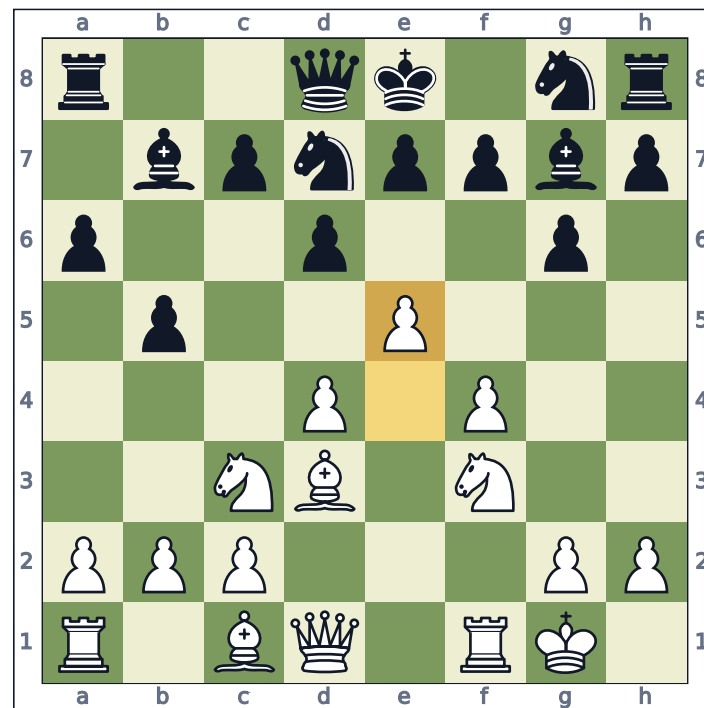
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black delays committing the center and seeks flexible counterplay from a fianchetto. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Occupy the center, develop behind it, and expand only when the king is safe.

BLACK'S PLAN

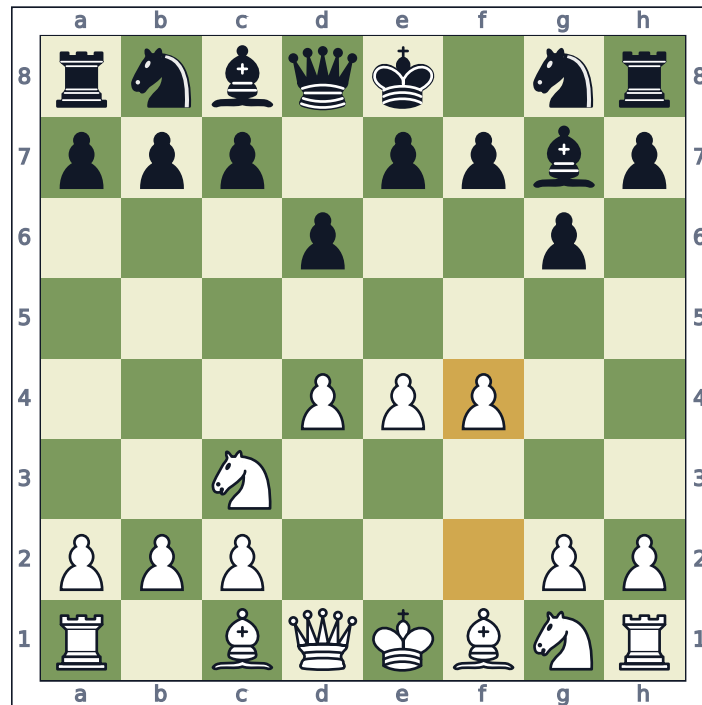
Attack the center with ...c5 or ...e5 and use queenside space without neglecting development.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

...c5 and ...e5 are Black's key choices; White's e5 can gain space and time.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - Black to move

THEME

A queenside pawn advance can threaten ...b4, dislodging the defender of e4.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

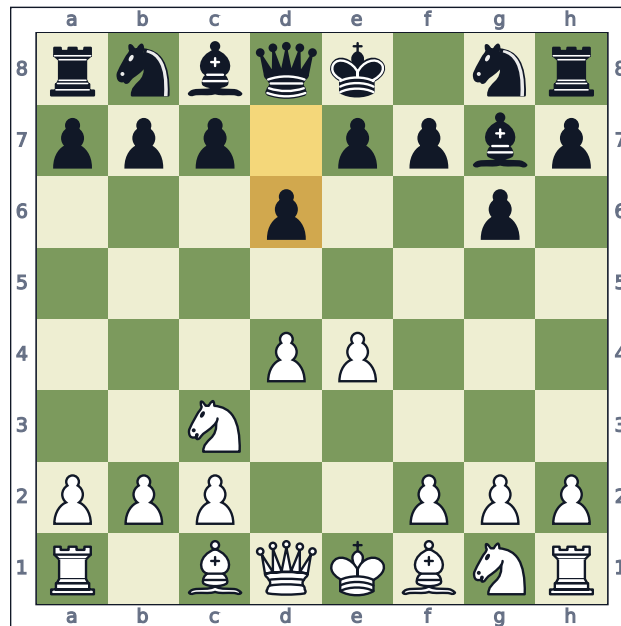
Confusing flexibility with permission to leave pieces undeveloped.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black delays committing the center and seeks flexible counterplay from a fianchetto.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: ...c5 and ...e5 are Black's key choices; White's e5 can gain space and time.

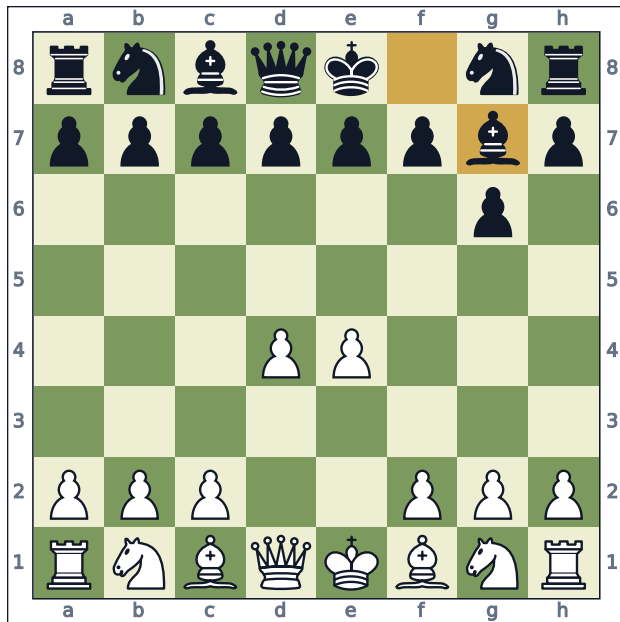
MEMORY SENTENCE

Delay commitment, not development forever.

ACTIVE RECALL

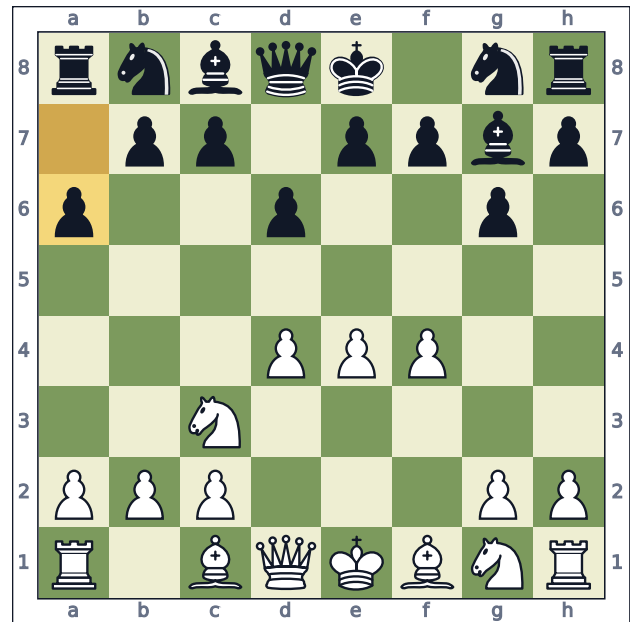
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Nc3. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: Nf3. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Occupy the center, develop behind it, and expand only when the king is safe. Black: Attack the center with ...c5 or ...e5 and use queenside space without neglecting development. Lever: ...c5 and ...e5 are Black's key choices; White's e5 can gain space and time.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.